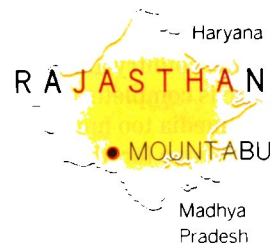


Mythical Solitude

A tranquil valley is the site for a temple with a spring and 1,200-year-old holy fire. What's missing are the tourists.



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THE FIRE THAT
NEVER GOES OUT

By Rohit Parihar

Far from the throngs of tourists at Mount Abu, the only hill station in Rajasthan, a flame has continuously flickered in a deep valley for nearly 1,200 years. Legend says the sacred fire is burning since the days of the Mahabharata and Ramayana. The place is called Gomukh, for the constant stream of water flowing through a marble-sculpted cow's mouth. The 800 steps carved out into the valley in the Aravalli hills pass through a thick forest. The only sounds to be heard are from birds and animals as the area is part of a bear sanctuary, some of which even drink water from Gomukh.

The place was visited by Rajendra Prasad, who later became India's first president, in 1948 and wrote in the visitors' book: "This is the most beautiful of all places in Mount Abu." Even President Pratibha Patil went there, though she did not climb down all the steps. Though a landslide destroyed the old Krishna temple in 1973, but the main temple survived. Guides discourage tourists from visiting Gomukh as they earn little from it. Still, a few thousand do visit the place every month, with the

numbers snowballing to 20,000 during the Guru Purnima fair in July. During this time, the erstwhile royalty of Sirohi decorates the black stone deity with a crown and jewellery, which is returned after prayers. The hermitage has an idol of Indra and a stone inscription of Maharana Kumbha, a great Rajput warrior.

A mix of myth and history, the sacred fire is believed to have given birth to four Rajput lineages—Parihars, Parmars, Chauhans and Solankis. Historians describe it as the place where a fire ritual purified the Kshatriya and Rajput clans after they married into Central Asian tribes. Now controlled by the Nimbhag Sampradaya Peeth, based near Ajmer, it was also supposed to be sage Vashisht's hermitage. Despite these interesting tales, the place is not popular. Part of the reason is the opposition from the priests. "We do not want too many tourists anyway," says the young caretaker, Sankadiksan. The priests want to maintain the sanctity of the place, even if that means anonymity. A holy solitude, one could say.